

BUS 450 Presentation Defense

Topic Title

Sugar-Related Claims, and Knowledge Perspective & Its Impact On Purchase Intention Toward Sweetened Beverages - The Moderating Role Of Health Consciousness Among Gen Z Via Short-Form Videos/ User Generated Content

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TABLE OF CONTENTS

01 Introduction

02 Literature Review

03 Methodology

04 Data Analysis & Findings

05 Discussion & Recommendations

I. INTRODUCTION

+50 countries

have adopted sugar-sweetened beverage (SSB) taxes

Euromonitor International, 2022
;Innova Market Insights, 2024

8%–10%

the excise tax range VN plans for SSBs in 2027 - 2028

(Viet Nam News, 2025)

40% tax rate

min rate recommended to effectively reduce consumption and encourage healthier product innovation

(Nhat, 2025)

Supported strategies:

- Low reduction trend in F&B industry.
- Australia's Health Star Rating (2014) rates packaged foods from 0.5 to 5 stars.
(Seenivasan et al., 2024)
- Singapore's Nutri-Grade assigns beverages grades A–D, with D products banned from advertising.
(Shin et al., 2023)

WHY THIS STUDY MATTERS

1 Even healthier versions of SSB are frequently overconsumed, contributing to obesity and related health risks (Brownbill et al., 2018a). Whether sugar-related claims effectively shape consumption behavior ?

2 Most of the existing literature targets either children or older adults (Fleming-Milici et al., 2022)
(Agarwal, 2023)

3 Most existing research is based in developed countries (Bernstein et al., 2017; Brownbill et al., 2018b).

Little is known about how lower-middle-income countries like Vietnam interpret health claims across different cultural, digital, and regulatory contexts.

4 The role of knowledge professionalism and persuasion knowledge, Gen Z's confidence in assessing product information, remains underexplored

PROBLEM STATEMENT

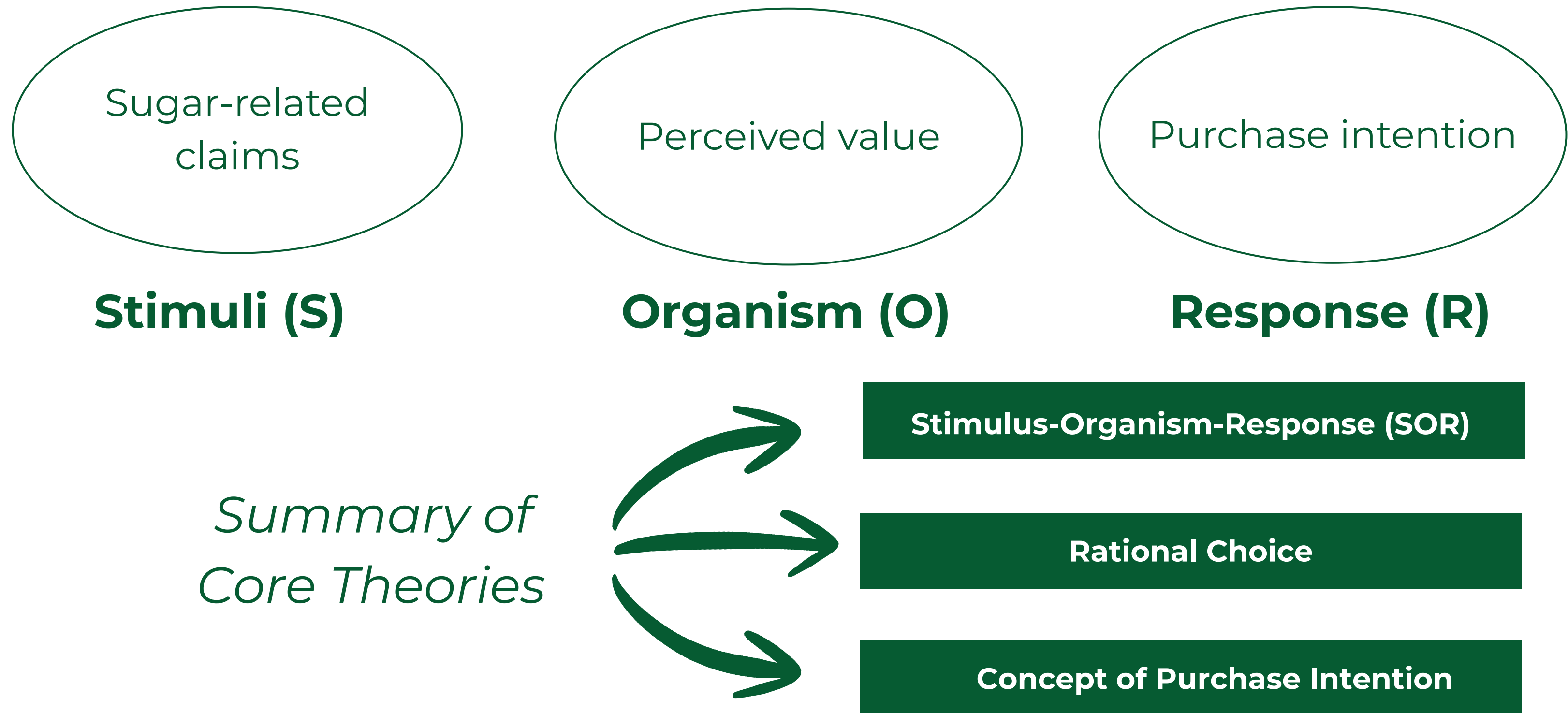
There is an **“URGENT NEED”** to:

- Investigate how sugar-related claims, persuasion knowledge, and knowledge professionalism interact to shape SSB consumption among Gen Z consumers in Vietnam
- Identify how these relationships are further influenced by their level of health consciousness, a combination of factors, that is underexplored but critical for advancing both marketing and public health strategies.

RESEARCH OBJECTIVES

- (1)** To examine the impact of sugar-related claims on Gen Z's purchase intention toward sweetened beverages.
- (2)** To investigate how persuasion knowledge influences Gen Z's evaluation of sugar-related claims in short-form videos.
- (3)** To analyze the effect of knowledge professionalism on purchase intention.
- (4)** To determine the moderating role of health consciousness in the relationship between perceived value and purchase intention.

II. LITERATURE REVIEW



1. SOR MODEL

Mehrabian & Russell (1974)



Stimuli (S)

Attractive designs, credible content creators, and positive online reviews can increase trust and purchase intention (Wang et al., 2024; Kumsawat et al., 2025; Zhu et al. 2020)

Sugar-related claims could similarly impact purchase intention by shaping consumers' perception of healthfulness & product quality.

1. SOR MODEL

Mehrabian & Russell (1974)

PV and social influences mediate the impact of online stimuli on GenZ PI

(Sun & Xing 2022)

This evaluation blends both rational and emotional elements, including expected taste, perceived health benefits, and price fairness (Sweeney & Soutar, 2001)



↑ PV -> ↑ PI

-> Favours the mediating role of PV between digital stimuli and PI (Zhu et al., 2020; Sun & Xing, 2022)

2. RATIONAL CHOICE MODEL

Individuals are assumed to maximize utility based on preferences, available information, and constraints (Becker, 1976; Simon, 1978)

Consumers evaluate alternatives by weighing perceived benefits vs. perceived costs, including both tangible and intangible attributes (McFadden, 1986)



McCarthy et al. (2017) found that sugar level was the most important attribute for plant-based beverages and sugar free options led consumers to achieve a higher self-esteem.



Through claims, consumers focus more on health benefits, taste expectations, and social image, while also considering trade-offs.



Accuracy of these decisions depends on the quality and completeness of information provided on labels (Bandara, 2016).

Duong et al. (2020) found that undergraduate students with higher eHealth literacy engaged more actively in positive health-promoting behaviors.

3. CONCEPT OF PURCHASE INTENTION

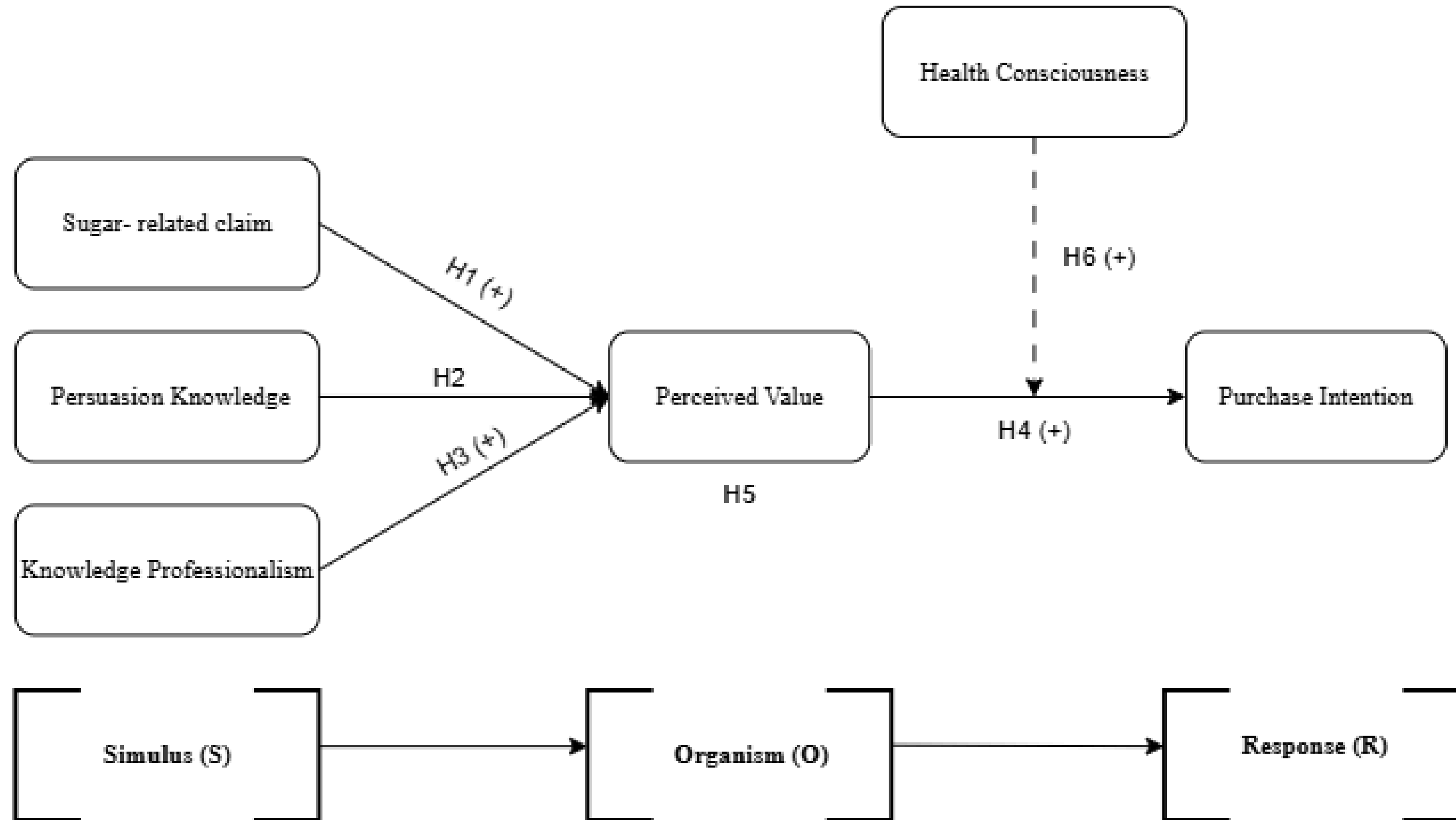
A subjective tendency of consumers to purchase products, which only represents a major indicator of consumer behavior (Hill, 1975)

An individual's conscious plan or willingness to make an effort to purchase a specific product or service in the future (Spears & Singh, 2004)

The moment when perception turns into a decision that reflects how ready and willing consumers are to buy a product in the near future. It does not guarantee action, but it is one of the strongest predictors of actual buying behavior.

PI has been widely treated as a response in the SOR model in many recent researches (Zhu, 2020; Sultan et al., 2021, Sun & Xing 2022, Wang et al., 2024; Kumsawat et al. 2025).

PROPOSED RESEARCH MODEL



SUGAR-RELATED CLAIM (SC)



Alsaeed et al. (2025) defined a stimulus as an environmental cue affecting users' internal states.

Widely used on packaging and advertisements to signal nutritional benefits and project a healthier image

Many consumers perceive "no added sugar" to mean that the product contains no sugar at all, even when natural sugars are present (Andrews et al., 2011) .

Thus, this study proposes:

H1: Sugar-related claim has a positive effect on Gen Z's purchase intention toward sweetened beverages.

PERSUASION KNOWLEDGE (PK)

The set of beliefs consumers hold about marketers' motives, strategies, and tactics, enabling them to recognize and evaluate persuasion attempts (Friestad & Wright, 1994).

As consumers gain more exposure to advertising, they become more skeptical toward overly promotional messages.

Tutaj & van Reijmersdal (2012) showed PK altered PI depending on perceived credibility.

Thus, this study proposes:

H2: Persuasion Knowledge has a significant effect on Gen Z's purchase intention toward sweetened beverages.

KNOWLEDGE PROFESSIONALISM (KP)

Depth, accuracy, and reliability of knowledge an individual possesses in a specific domain, enabling them to make informed and critical decisions (Shanteau, 1992).

It reflects consumers' ability to interpret labels, ingredients, and health-related claims accurately.

An active cognitive filter as knowledgeable consumers are more likely to recognize real benefits, leading to higher PV.

Higher knowledge professionalism, either objective or subjective knowledge, strengthens Gen Z consumers' confidence in their decisions and increases their PI.

Brucks (1985)

Thus, this study proposes:

H3: Knowledge professionalism has a positive effect on Gen Z consumers' purchase intention toward sweetened beverages.

MEDIATING ROLE OF PERCEIVED VALUE (PV)

How consumers weigh what they gain vs what they give up when choosing a product. It is not simply about price or quality, but about whether the product feels worth it

(Zeithaml, 1988); (Patterson & Spreng, 1997)

Higher PV enhances consumer willingness to pay and purchase likelihood, even when actual product quality is unchanged (Sweeney & Soutar, 2001)

In the context of SSBs, PV is shaped by taste expectations, health perceptions, and price fairness, which are critical factors in influencing PI

(Sweeney & Soutar, 2001; Sun & Xing, 2022)

Thus, this study proposes:

H4: PV has a positive effect on Gen Z consumers' PI toward sweetened beverages.

H5a: PV mediates the relationship between SC and PI.

H5b: PV mediates the relationship between PK and PI.

H5c: PV mediates the relationship between KP and PI.

MODERATING ROLE OF HEALTH CONSCIOUSNESS (HC)

The degree to which individuals are aware of, concerned about, and motivated to take actions that promote their health (Michaelidou & Hassan, 2008).

HC reflects the extent to which Gen Z consumers actively consider the health implications of sugar intake, evaluate nutritional information, and integrate this awareness into purchase decisions.

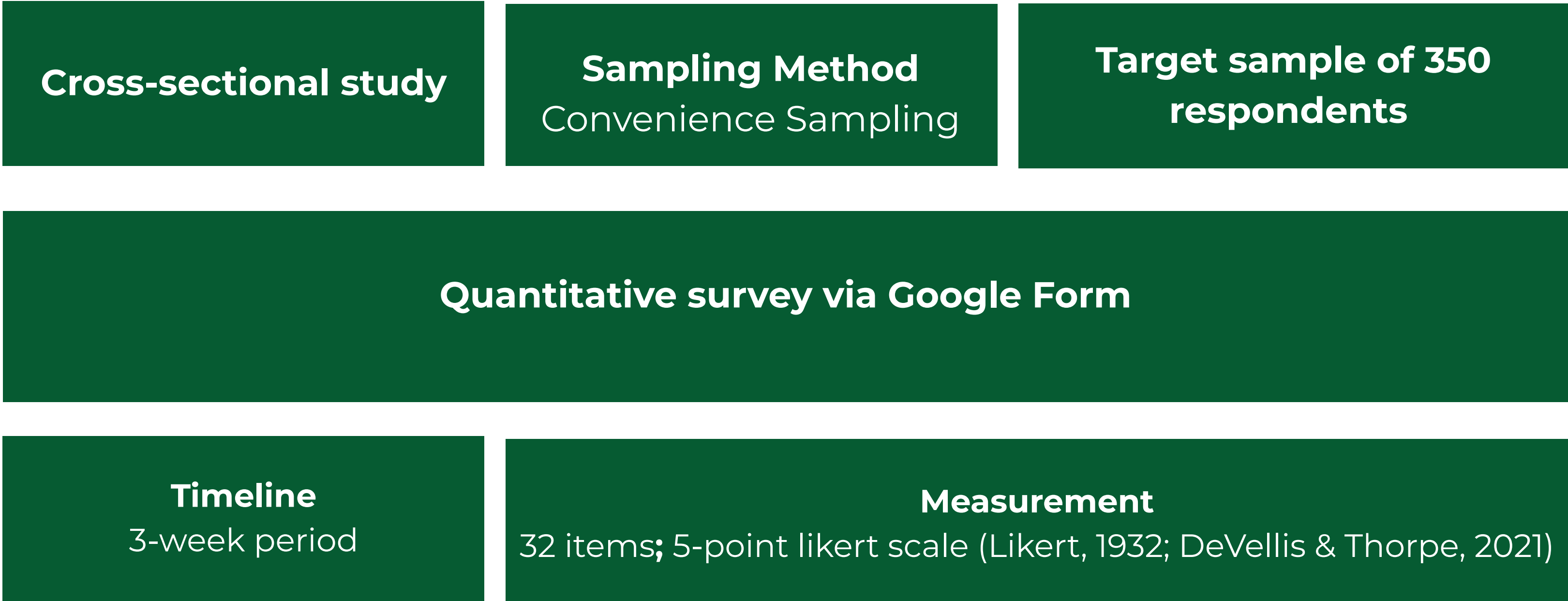
Research shows that consumers with higher health awareness react more strongly to health claims. In contrast, less health-conscious consumers tend to prioritize taste or social appeal, weakening this relationship.

Thus, this study proposes:

H6: Health consciousness positively moderates the relationship between perceived value and Gen Z consumers' purchase intention toward sweetened beverages.

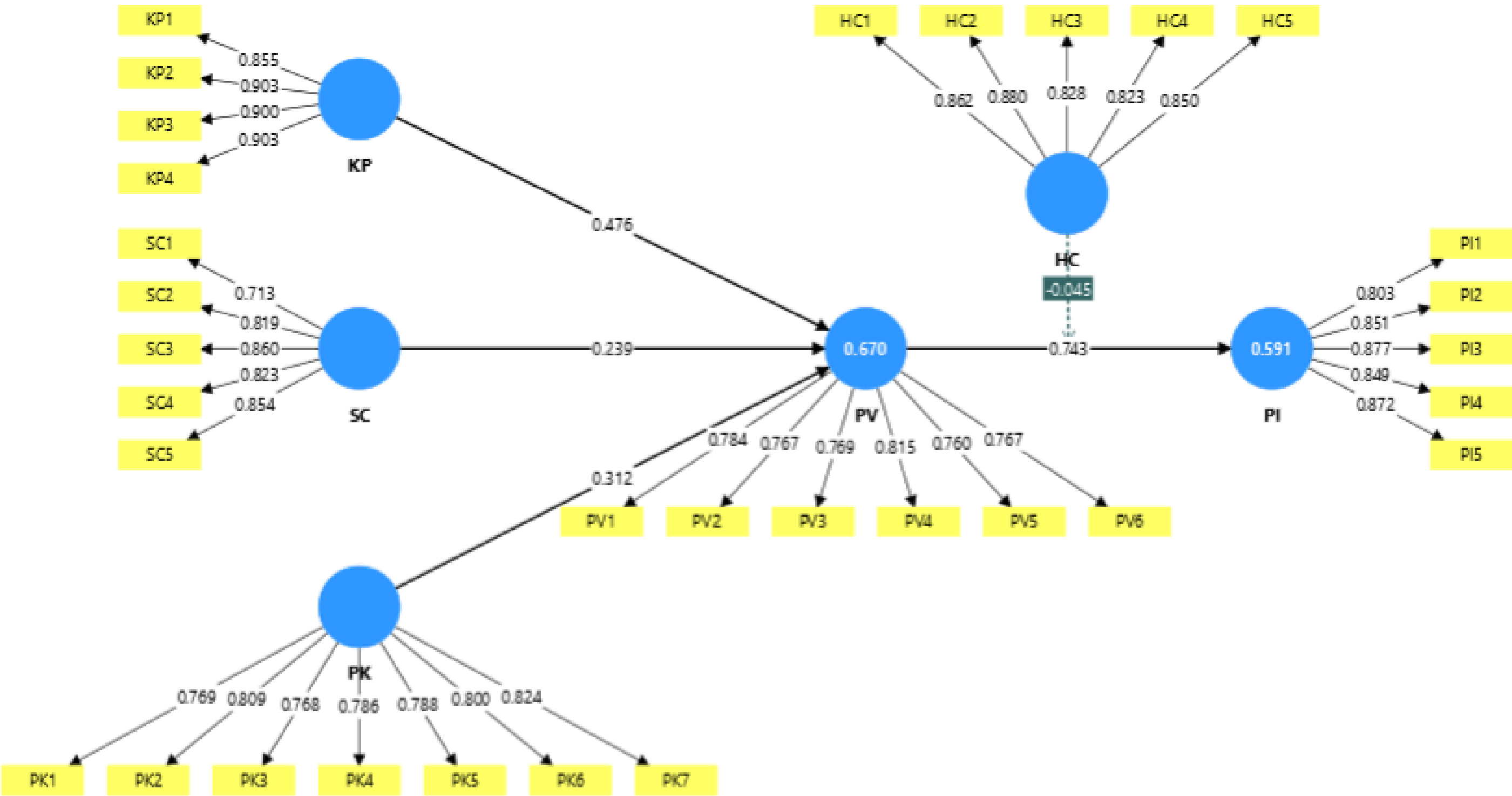
III. METHODOLOGY

DATA COLLECTION



DATA ANALYSIS TOOL

Smart PLS 4.0



MEASUREMENT SCALE

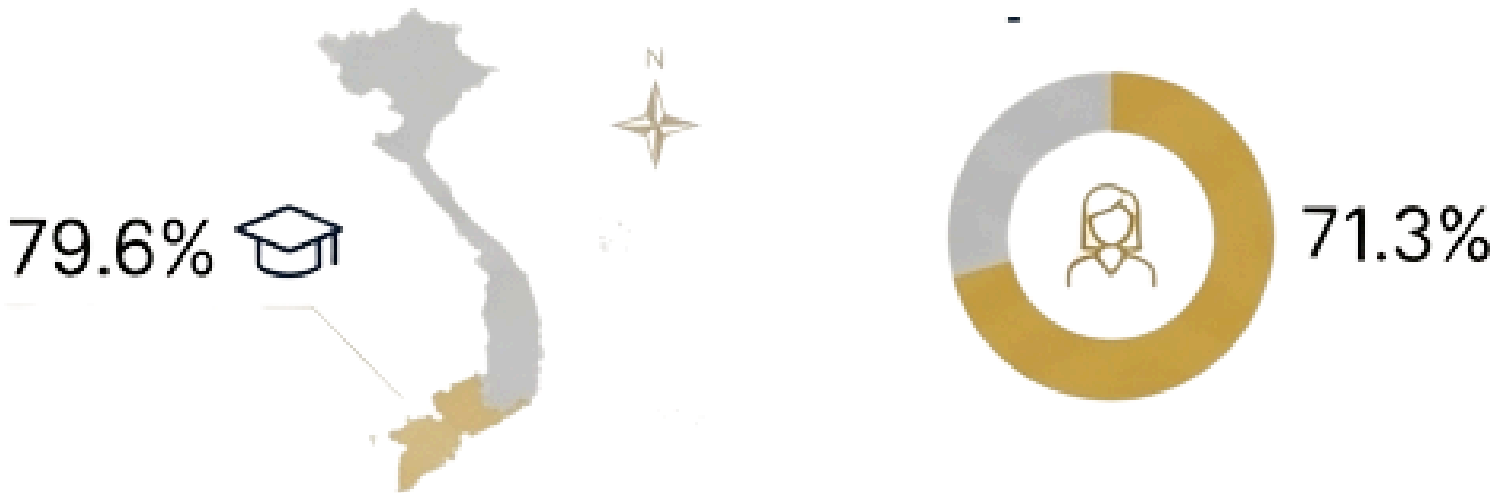
- Sugar-related Claims (SC): 5 items
(Lalor et al., 2011)
- Knowledge professionalism (KP): 4 items
(Ohanian, 1991)
- Persuasion Knowledge (PK): 7 items
(Tutaj & Van Reijmersdal, 2012)
- Perceived value (PV): 6 items
(Wiedmann et al., 2009; Wongkitrungrueng and Assarut, 2020)
- Health consciousness (HC): 5 items
(Kutnohorska and Tomšík, 2013)
- Purchase intention (PI): 5 items
(Park and Lin, 2020; Tarkiainen and Sundqvist, 2005)

CONDITIONED RESPONDENT

- Participants are aged 13-28, Gen Z (Zillennials) those born after 1997-2012 (Cilliers, 2017; Widawska, 2021).
- Reside in Vietnam
- Have often purchased or consumed SSBs
- Sample size: 250
- Valid sample: 230

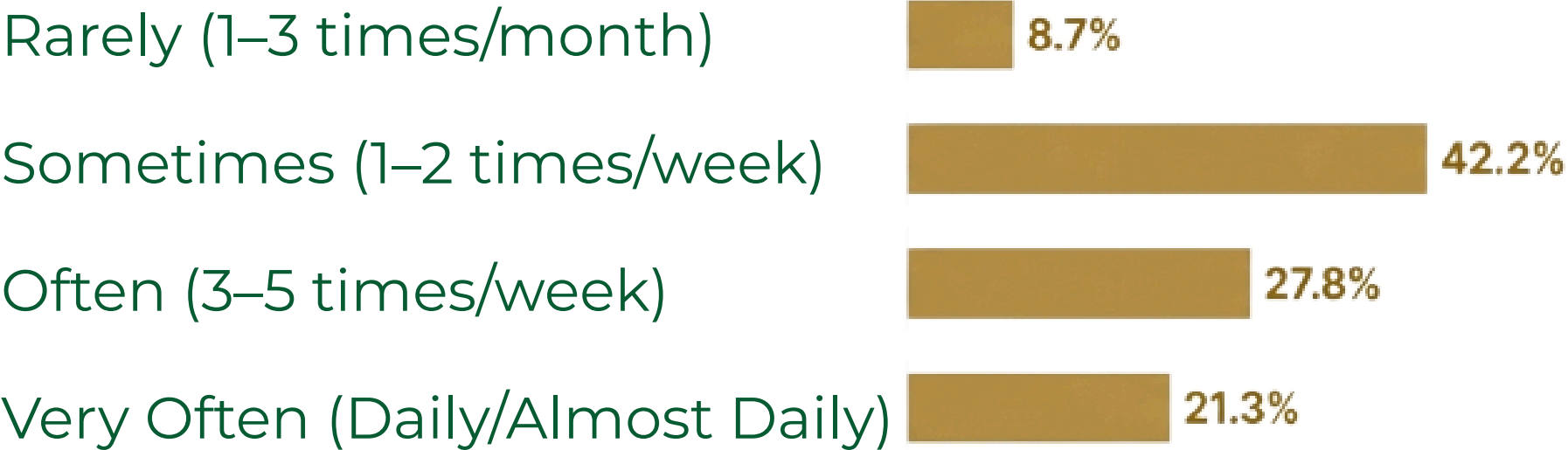
IV. DATA ANALYSIS & FINDINGS

Key Demographics



- Gender: Female 71.3%, Male 27.8%
- Occupation: Students 67.0%,
Working students 22.2%
- Monthly Income: 62.2% earn below 5M VND
- Education: 79.6% hold a College/Bachelor's degree
- Primarily drawn from Vietnam's Southern

Frequency of Sweetened Drink Consumption



MEASUREMENT MODEL

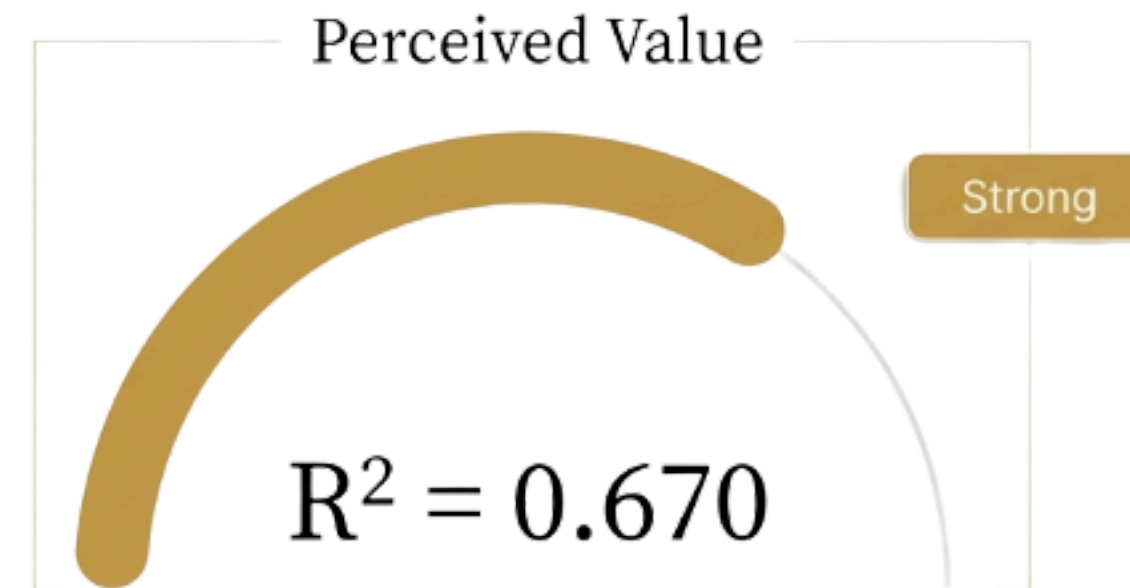
Reliability & Convergent Validity

- Indicator loadings $> 0.7 \rightarrow$ No item removed
- Cronbach's α & Composite Reliability > 0.8
- AVE > 0.5 (min AVE = 0.604)

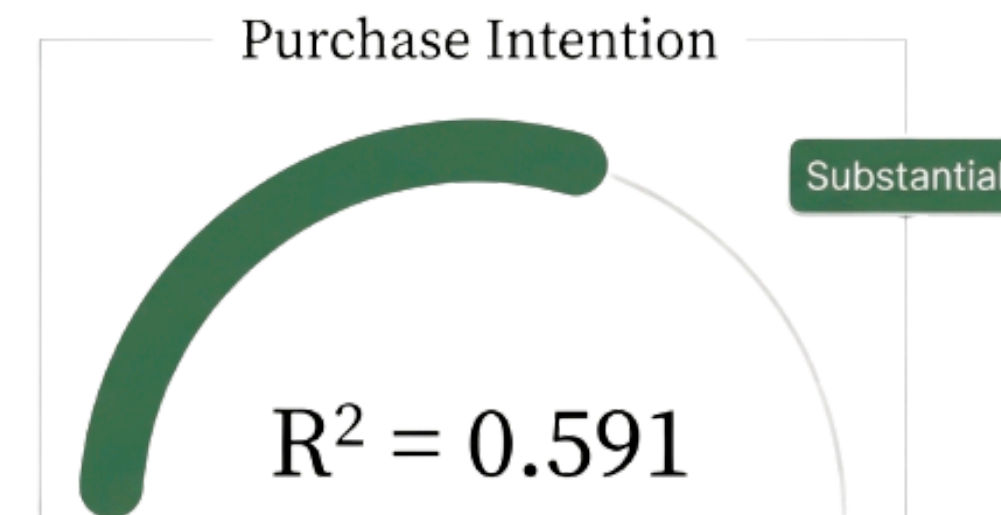
Discriminant Validity

- Fornell–Larcker criterion satisfied
- HTMT ratios < 1 (95% CI excludes 1)
- Cross-loadings: highest on own construct

Model Quality



67% of the variance in PV is explained by SC, PK, and KP.



59.1% of the variance in PI is explained by the model's predictors.

DIRECT & MEDIATION ANALYSIS

All paths significant at 1% level

- SC → PI (positive)
- PK → PI (positive)
- KP → PI (positive)
- PV → PI (strongest effect)

Marketing claims & consumer knowledge don't just impact PI directly; the primary influence is channeled through PV.

All 3 antecedents operate through PV, reinforcing its mediator role.

PV → PI

Path Coefficient (β) = 0.743

Effect Size (f^2) = 1.023

While all direct paths were significant, the link between PV and PI was the most powerful by a wide margin.

The next strongest direct effect on PI was KP (β = 0.353). PV's influence is **more than double**.

DETAILED STRUCTURAL MODEL RESULTS

All hypothesized direct paths and mediation effects (H1–H5c) were found to be statistically significant at the $p < 0.001$ level

Structural Estimates and Mediation Effects				
Hypothesis	Path	Coefficient (β)	p-Value	95% Confidence Interval [BCa CI]
H1	SC -> PI	0.178	<0.001	[0.097, 0.262]
H2	PK -> PI	0.232	<0.001	[0.166, 0.299]
H3	KP -> PI	0.353	<0.001	[0.270, 0.433]
H4	PV -> PI	0.743	<0.001	[0.649, 0.820]
H5a	SC -> PV -> PI	significant		
H5b	PK -> PV -> PI	significant		
H5c	KP -> PV -> PI	significant		

Analysis conducted using PLS-SEM with bootstrapping. R^2 (PV) = 0.670; R^2 (PI) = 0.591. No collinearity issues detected ($VIF < 3$).

THE SURPRISING TWIST: HEALTH CONSCIOUSNESS DOESN'T CHANGE THE OUTCOME.

We hypothesized that a consumer's level of HC would amplify the effect of PV on PI.
The data showed otherwise.

HC × PV → PI
“insignificant” ✗
p-Value: 0.137 (p > .05)

The results were statistically insignificant for the interaction term ($t=1.488$, $p>.05$).
Thus, HC does not moderate the relationship between PV and PI, and thereby, it does **not support hypothesis H6**.

V. DISCUSSION & RECOMMENDATIONS

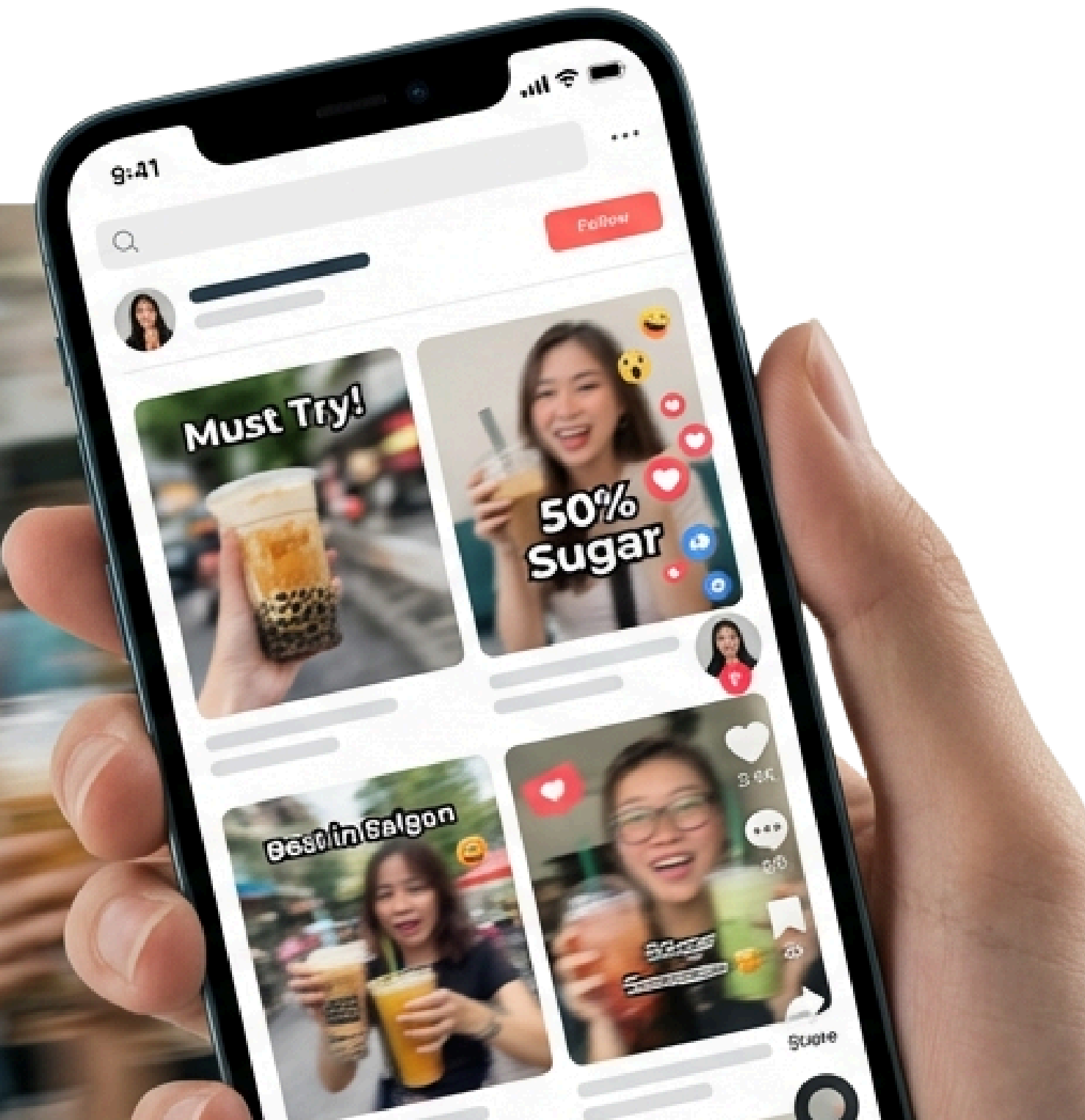
Surprise #1: Marketing-savvy consumers are more likely to buy, not less.

Knowledge doesn't automatically create skepticism. It creates a demand for credibility.

Key Insight

Gen Z uses their knowledge to filter out exaggerated messages. Clear, factual claims are interpreted as signs of brand confidence and respect for the consumer's intelligence.

In short-form video contexts, such claims may be especially effective when embedded in authentic influencer narratives, especially in this era of KOCs product information easily reaches the ears of mass consumers.



V. DISCUSSION & RECOMMENDATIONS

Surprise #2: The final decision isn't about claims. It's about Value.

**What builds value for Gen Z?
A combination of clear signals**

It's not just one thing. Gen Z's sense of value is built when a clear health signal (the claim) is delivered by a credible source (professionalism) in a way that feels honest (persuasion knowledge).

Knowledge Professionalism ($\beta=0.476$)

Persuasion Knowledge ($\beta=0.312$)

Sugar-related Claim ($\beta=0.239$)



V. DISCUSSION & RECOMMENDATIONS

Surprise #3: Once PV is formed, it drives PI regardless of consumers' health orientation.

Supported

Zaki et al. (2025) and Ge et al. (2025) reported an insignificant role of HC in sugary and carbonated drink consumption

Even health-aware Gen Z consumers remain strongly influenced by branding, taste, and affordability (Cording, 2025; Opeepl, 2024)

Contrasted

Pior studies showing that HC strengthens attitudes and intentions toward healthy products (Nikbin et al., 2025; Dimitrova & Ilieva, 2023; Fathin et al., 2023; Wimardian et al., 2025).

A possible explanation is population-specific factors, such as socioeconomic status, gender differences, and high media exposure, which may override HC in indulgent beverage choices.



Make Labels Intuitive

- Adopt clear, visual, front-of-pack systems (like Nutri-Scores or traffic lights) that can be understood at a glance, reducing cognitive load.
- Back-of-pack nutrition information labeling has yet to be implemented in Vietnam compared to other Southeast Asian countries

(Pettigrew et al., 2022)

LIMITATIONS & FUTURE RESEARCH DIRECTIONS

1. Limit

The sample is skewed toward female, student, and low-income respondents concentrated in southern Vietnam, which limits generalizability.

Directions

Employs larger and more diverse samples, extend to other regions/countries, including additional variables such as social norms, reference groups, and lifestyle factors (e.g., physical activity), which may further shape responses to sugar-related claims.

Longitudinal designs are also recommended to capture evolving over time.

LIMITATIONS & FUTURE RESEARCH DIRECTIONS

2. Limit

Exclusive use of quantitative PLS-SEM restricts deeper insight into why HC did not moderate the PVxPI relationship.

Directions

Qualitative or mixed-method approaches
To explore how Gen Z interprets sugar information, negotiates trade-offs between taste and health, and evaluates acceptable sugar levels.

Comparing the effectiveness of sugar-related claims versus health warning messages may provide key insights of message framing effects.

Thank You So Much!

BUS 450 Defense

Greatly appreciate your valuable feedback to help
further improve and refine this study

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